The Lived Experiences of Incarcerated Mothers: Effect of Imprisonment Impact on Material Function and Family Dynamic

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Motherhood is not simply a biological status but a complex socio-emotional role involving caregiving, nurturing, guidance and sustained connection with one's children. The demands on mothers are considerable—yet not all are able to fulfil these responsibilities due to life circumstances such as separation, migration or incarceration. Incarceration of a mother introduces a profound disruption not only in her own maternal functioning but also in the relational fabric of her family. Parenting from behind bars has been described as fraught with multiple barriers to role performance, emotional bonding and family continuity (Paynter et al., 2022).

In Canada, incarcerated mothers reported emotional distress, logistical and financial barriers in sustaining relationships with their children and families (Paynter et al., 2022). Children of incarcerated mothers had higher risk scores across a range of adversities including preterm birth, low birthweight, out-of-home care placement compared to children without maternal incarceration exposure (Bell et al., 2024). While children exposed to maternal incarceration alone and especially when combined with other adversities had increased odds of below average reading and numeracy attainment (McGee, 2023). Maternal incarceration not only disrupts maternal functions, but alters family dynamics and child outcomes globally (Herreros- Fraile et al., 2023).

Whereas in the Philippines, analogous issues of maternal separation and family disruption are well documented globally and suggest the Philippine is likely to reflect similar dynamics. Given the increasing female incarcerated population and multiple responsibilities of Filipino mothers, incarceration poses a risk to both maternal identity and family stability. The intersection of

caregiving, maternal absence, economic strain and stigma merits focused attention in the local setting (Donato et al., 2023).

The experiences of incarcerated mothers reveal the intersection of motherhood, social stigma, and institutional constraints. Understanding these lived experiences is vital in uncovering how imprisonment reshapes maternal functions and family dynamics. This study seeks to explore the emotional, psychological, and social adjustments of mothers behind bars, and how they cope with the limitations imposed by incarceration. By focusing on their lived realities, this research aims to give voice to an often-overlooked population and shed light on the broader implications for family welfare and child development.

This study holds significance for multiple sectors. For correctional institutions, it can inform policies and rehabilitation programs that support maternal roles within confinement. For social workers and psychologists, the findings may serve as a basis for designing family-centered interventions that maintain mother–child relationships. For policymakers, the study emphasizes the need for humane correctional practices that recognize motherhood as a vital component of rehabilitation and reintegration. Lastly, for future researchers, it contributes to the growing body of literature on gender, incarceration, and family studies in the Philippine context.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

Motherhood within the context of incarceration presents unique emotional, psychological, and social challenges that deeply affect both mothers and their families. Studies have shown that imprisonment disrupts maternal roles, weakens family bonds, and hinders communication between mothers and their children. Institutional policies and prison conditions often limit opportunities for nurturing and emotional connection, further intensifying feelings of guilt, anxiety, and isolation. Despite these challenges, many incarcerated mothers develop coping

mechanisms and rely on support systems—such as counseling, faith, and family visits—to sustain their sense of motherhood. Understanding these lived experiences is essential in promoting rehabilitation, family stability, and more compassionate correctional policies.

Emotional and Psychological Experiences of Incarcerated Mothers

Incarcerated mothers often endure profound emotional turbulence, grappling with guilt, separation anxiety and loss of maternal identity. Likewise, their psychological landscape is marked by heightened stress, identity disruption and diminished self-efficacy. Their spiritual experience frequently becomes a source of solace or conflict, as they turn to faith, hope and meaning-making while facing the challenges of confinement (Baker, 2021).

Emotional Distress and Maternal Guilt

Maternal guilt is a profound emotional response experienced by mothers who are separated from their children, whether due to incarceration, work obligations, or other circumstances. Mothers who are forcibly separated from their children often experience heightened levels of guilt, anxiety, and depression. According to Poehlmann (2005), incarcerated mothers reported persistent feelings of remorse and self-blame for their inability to provide day-to-day care for their children, which often exacerbated their psychological distress. Similarly, Arditti et al. (2010) emphasize that maternal guilt is not only a reaction to separation but also a reflection of societal expectations of motherhood, which places emotional pressure on mothers to maintain a continuous presence in their children's lives despite challenging circumstances.

The emotional burden of separation extends beyond guilt, manifesting in long-term anxiety, sadness, and longing that can affect mothers' overall mental health. Mothers separated from their children reported difficulties in maintaining emotional connections, leading to feelings of helplessness and chronic emotional pain. Moreover, Swanson et al. (2021) explained that the

trauma of separation can disrupt maternal identity, contributing to stress and depressive symptoms. Psychosocial support systems are important to mitigate the emotional consequences of forced maternal separation and help mothers cope with the complex interplay of guilt, longing, and anxiety.

Incarcerated mothers undergo a wide range of intense emotional experiences, often struggling with guilt, loneliness, fear, and longing for their children while adapting to life behind bars. In addition, others experience deep emotional separation, guilt, and helplessness as they are deprived of opportunities to care for and nurture their children. Institutional restrictions—such as limited visitation, surveillance, and rigid communication rules—further hinder meaningful mother–child interaction, reinforcing feelings of shame and inadequacy. Stigmatization from correctional personnel and society aggravates these struggles, causing many mothers to internalize guilt and question their worthiness as parents. Nonetheless, resilience among mothers who find alternative ways to sustain bonds, such as letter writing, creating handmade gifts, or maintaining emotional connection through faith and reflection. The need for family- centered and trauma-informed interventions within correctional systems to preserve maternal identity, strengthen communication, and minimize the adverse effects of separation on both

mother and child, illustrating how incarceration fragments but does not entirely sever the essence of motherhood (Walsh et al.,2023).

Consequently, incarcerated mothers sustain emotional bonds with their children through storytelling, prayer, and acts of creativity such as writing letters and crafting gifts. These practices as coping mechanisms that preserve maternal identity and dignity amidst dehumanizing prison conditions. Personal faith and spiritual conviction serve as central pillars of strength for imprisoned mothers. These maternal expressions are acts of resistance against institutional separation and identity loss. Correctional rehabilitation should incorporate structured opportunities for creative expression and family contact. Such approaches can strengthen emotional resilience and nurture hope for reintegration (Aquino, 2023).

As experienced, most of the participants felt distress during the first few months of their incarceration. The sources of this are attributed to self-blaming, loneliness, anxieties and difficulty in adapting to their new situation. Self-blaming is considered as a common reaction to stressful events like incarceration. They don't have anybody to blame but themselves. And as a result, some participants recognize what they have done and express regrets as to what they have done. It is noted that distress is the result of experiencing incongruence between former meanings and purposes in life and new meanings that are experienced, for example, after committing an impulsive act of violence (Donato et al., 2023).

Incarceration disrupts family roles and responsibilities in multiple ways depending on the life cycle stage. For inmates in the beginning and child-bearing stages, incarceration created emotional strain due to distance from family and financial burdens as fathers were unable to provide, forcing wives to assume the breadwinner role. The silence surrounding incarceration also risked negatively affecting children's emotional well-being. In later stages, incarceration

intensified dysfunction as ties with spouses and children weakened or were cut, leading to both emotional abandonment and economic deprivation. While some families managed to reorganize and adapt, others experienced complete breakdown, highlighting how imprisonment destabilizes family systems. Although prison rehabilitation programs aim to prepare inmates for reintegration, the urgent need for parallel interventions to support the left-behind spouses and children through counseling, seminars, and strengthened family communication throughout the period of incarceration (Lobo, 2019).

Limited access to prenatal services, inadequate nutrition, and lack of privacy creates physical and emotional stress for expectant mothers. These institutional constraints compound their anxiety about childbirth and postnatal separation from infants. Emotional separation from family members intensifies their fear of losing parental bonds and identity. Despite these hardships, participants demonstrated remarkable resilienc e through social support among fellow inmates and spiritual faith. Systemic neglect within the penal health system undermines both maternal well-being and early mother–child attachment.

Maternal separation, whether due to incarceration or other circumstances, places an immense emotional burden on mothers, often manifesting as guilt, anxiety, and depression. The inability to provide daily care for their children leads many mothers to experience self-blame and a persistent sense of inadequacy, while societal expectations amplify the pressure to maintain a constant maternal presence. Emotional distress is further compounded by institutional restrictions, stigmatization, and disrupted family roles, creating feelings of helplessness, loneliness, and identity loss. Despite these challenges, mothers demonstrate resilience through creative expressions, storytelling, prayer, and maintaining emotional bonds, which serve to preserve maternal identity and hope amid separation. The experiences of

maternal separation reveal not only the psychological consequences for mothers but also highlight the critical need for supportive interventions—such as psychosocial programs, family-centered rehabilitation, and structured opportunities for connection—that can sustain maternal well-being and nurture family relationships during and after periods of separation.

Psychological Stress, Identity Disruption, and Mental Health

Psychologically, incarcerated mothers face overwhelming stress, anxiety, and identity disruption as they cope with separation from their children and the mental demands of prison life. Similarly, the strain of role redefinition among incarcerated mothers emphasized that women must reconstruct their sense of motherhood in prison settings where institutional restrictions prevent active caregiving. While separation creates deep psychological strain, mothers attempt to fulfill their maternal role through emotional connection—sending messages, providing moral guidance, and nurturing from afar. Such adaptive strategies show that even in confinement, mothers attempt to maintain influence over family life, but this is often insufficient to counterbalance the

disrupted family dynamic and weakened maternal function caused by long periods of separation (Havanon et al., 2023).

Imprisoned mothers experience elevated psychological stress and mental health challenges compared with the general population due to the compounded effects of incarceration and separation from their children (Thompson's, 2024). Mothers involved with the criminal justice system show high prevalence rates of depression, anxiety, and other mental disorders, with contributing factors including limited contact with children, poor social support, and stress related to custodial conditions that exacerbate pre-existing vulnerabilities (e.g., trauma and unstable life histories) (Sapkota et al., 2024). Similarly, incarcerated mothers often oscillate between feelings of attachment and abandonment, reflecting ambivalence and emotional distress connected to their constrained maternal role within prison settings. Emotional burdens associated with restricted maternal agency—such as loss of autonomy in caregiving—are linked to elevated anxiety, sadness, and identity strain that contribute to long-term mental health risks for incarcerated mothers Alirezaei and Roudsari (2023).

Incarceration also disrupts maternal identity**,** often leading to crises in self-concept and role fulfillment. According to Walsh's (2023) mothering from prison identifies pervasive themes of maternal identity crisis and perceived maternal failure as mothers struggle to maintain meaningful relationships with their children while confined. These disruptions are compounded by external stigma and internalized guilt, which undermine incarcerated mothers' sense of competence and self-worth in their maternal role. In the Philippines, incarcerated mothers frequently describe maternal self-loathing and identity conflict as they confront physical separation and societal judgments, further intensifying psychological strain and complicating their capacity to sustain a coherent maternal identity during and after incarceration. The redefinition and loss of maternal

identity in carceral contexts are central to the mental health experiences of incarcerated mothers and necessitate targeted psychosocial supports within correctional systems (Legaspi et al., 2025).

Parental incarceration affects the closeness between parents and their children, emphasizing the long-term consequences of separation caused by imprisonment. A consistent pattern of reduced emotional closeness and weaker parent–child bonds across diverse demographic groups, even after controlling for socioeconomic background, family structure, and prior disadvantage. Incarceration itself—not merely pre-existing family instability—plays an independent role in damaging parent–child relationships. Limited communication opportunities, emotional withdrawal, and the stigma associated with incarceration contribute to these relational gaps. Children of incarcerated parents often experience feelings of abandonment, resentment, and confusion, which hinder the restoration of healthy relationships after release. Implementation of relationship-focused programs within correctional systems, such as enhanced visitation, parenting support, and post-release family counseling, to rebuild trust and emotional bonds. Addressing relational strain is essential not only for family well-being but also for reducing intergenerational cycles of disadvantage (Turney and Wildeman, 2023).

Incarcerated mothers face profound psychological challenges as they navigate the dual demands of prison life and separation from their children, often experiencing heightened stress, anxiety, depression, and crises in maternal identity. The inability to perform caregiving roles, coupled with institutional restrictions and societal stigma, forces mothers to reconstruct their sense of motherhood, often through emotional connections such as letters, guidance, and moral support from a distance. Despite these adaptive strategies, long-term separation disrupts family dynamics, weakens parent–child bonds, and intensifies feelings of guilt, helplessness, and self-doubt, undermining maternal competence and well-being. The compounded effects of incarceration and separation highlight the critical need for psychosocial and relationship-focused

interventions that preserve maternal identity, foster family resilience, and mitigate the lasting emotional consequences for both mothers and children.

Coping Mechanisms and Emotional Resilience

Incarcerated mothers often turn to spirituality or faith as a source of comfort, resilience, and meaning, helping them navigate the hardships of imprisonment and maintain hope for the future. Moreover, incarcerated persons usually experience the existential spiritual struggle of finding meaning in a life of trauma, while living in an environment that creates and exacerbates suffering. This is borne out in the case study of Joseph, through whose experience we see the themes of trauma, spirituality, and healing as they pertain to incarcerated people. Spirituality, which addresses positive/negative spiritual coping mechanisms, interpersonal aspects of

spirituality/spiritual coping, and connection between spirituality and mental health; and Healing, which encompasses forgiveness and service as pathways to trauma-healing. One may understand spirituality as the search for the sacred, while "the sacred often directly references God or a higher power, any aspect of life may be deemed as sacred if it is perceived to have divine-like qualities, such as transcendence, boundlessness, ultimate meaning, and perfection" (Hylton, 2022).

Personal faith and spiritual conviction serve as central pillars of strength for imprisoned mothers. These maternal expressions are acts of resistance against institutional separation and identity loss. Correctional rehabilitation should incorporate structured opportunities for creative expression and family contact. Such approaches can strengthen emotional resilience and nurture hope for reintegration (Aquino, 2023).

Religion plays a vital role in the emotional and spiritual resilience of incarcerated women, serving as a foundation for redemption, purpose, and reintegration after imprisonment. Formerly incarcerated women use religion as a coping mechanism to mitigate the indignity of incarceration, rebuild their self-worth, and find meaning amid adversity. Through prayer, faith practices, and belonging to religious communities, they experience healing and post-traumatic growth that transcend their carceral trauma. Religion also fosters hope and altruism, motivating these women to reconnect with society and help others, reflecting a transformative spiritual journey that redefines their identity beyond incarceration. This suggests that spirituality provides not only solace during confinement but also a framework for sustained moral and emotional recovery post-release (Ford, 2024).

Institutional policies and conditions that affect the maternal functions of incarcerated mothers. Institutional policies and prison conditions significantly influence the ability of

Incarcerated mothers to perform their maternal roles, affecting their contact with children, parenting practices, and overall well-being. Furthermore, mothers' experiences indicated that the correctional system and policies, which were predominantly designed for men, do not adequately address the varied and complex needs of pregnant women, mothers, and their young children. Imprisonment of pregnant women and mothers with young children should be the last resort, and they should be provided with holistic, individually tailored support, most preferably in community settings, to address their multiple intersecting needs (Sapkota et al., 2022).

Incarcerated mothers sustain relationships with their children despite institutional constraints. Mothers use creative strategies such as letter writing, handmade gifts, and phone calls to maintain a sense of presence and connection. However, these efforts are frequently undermined by restrictive visiting environment s, costly communication systems, and logistical barriers. Interventions aimed at improving contact quality—through family-friendly visitation areas, affordable communication access, and staff training—are essential to support mothers' relational and emotional needs (Loper, 2022). The role of family and community support in helping incarcerated women cope with imprisonment. Strong ties with extended kin, faith communities, and mutual aid networks significantly enhance emotional resilience and reduce stress among incarcerated mothers. These support systems help sustain caregiving identities and facilitate smoother reentry into family life post-release. Correctional institutions should formalize family engagement initiatives to strengthen these external linkages (Pamungkas et al., 2024).

A study by Misoles, Cabrera, and Susada (2024) delves into the lived experiences of mothers deprived of liberty in Davao Oriental, Philippines. Central themes identified include the pain of

maternal separation, longing for familial connection, and the feeling of guilt and helplessness brought about by limited opportunities for communication and visitation. The physical conditions and policies of the jail environment constrain maternal roles, deepening the emotional distance between mothers and their children. Despite these challenges, the resilience of incarcerated mothers who seek emotional survival through faith, peer support, and hope for family reunification. The need for family-centered correctional programs and psychosocial interventions that promote sustained maternal bonding and emotional well-being even within confinement.

Disruption of Maternal Roles and Caregiving

Incarceration profoundly disrupts mothers' capacity to nurture, guide, discipline, and provide emotional care to their children, often resulting in profound role strain and role loss**.** Incarcerated mothers experience persistent tension between their maternal responsibilities and the constraints of prison life, with physical separation, limited communication, societal stigma, and restricted decision-making undermining their traditional caregiving roles (Thongyou et al., 2023). This role strain often leads to emotional distress and feelings of inadequacy as women struggle to reconcile their identities as caregivers with the institutional limitations of imprisonment, forcing many to redefine maternal roles around limited contact, emotional support, and collaborations with caregivers outside prison (Walsh et al., 2023).

Despite these constraints, many incarcerated mothers continue to engage in "parenting from prison" or "mothering at a distance"**,** sustaining emotional bonds and caregiving identities through indirect means. When mothers maintain contact—through phone calls, letters, or structured parenting programs—their sense of connection and role competence can be partially preserved even in the absence of daily caregiving activities (Muhammad, 2024). Incarcerated women creatively sustain parenting through conversations and emotional support despite extreme

physical separation, emphasizing that maternal engagement persists even amid structural barriers. Interventions such as parenting support groups within correctional settings also reinforce maternal identity and caregiving confidence by offering strategies for facilitating caregiver communication and understanding child development from a distance (Dawson, 2015).

Incarcerated mothers rely on faith, spirituality, and creative strategies to cope with the hardships of separation and preserve their maternal identity. While institutional restrictions and societal stigma limit caregiving and create role strain, mothers maintain bonds through letters, calls, gifts, and parenting programs, demonstrating resilience and hope. Support from family, peers, and faith communities further sustains emotional well-being, emphasizing the need for family-centered correctional programs that nurture maternal function and relational continuity even within confinement.

Communication Barriers and Mother–Child Interaction

Restricted communication systems within correctional facilities create substantial barriers that impede mother–child interaction for incarcerated mothers. Institutional policies often limit the frequency and form of contact allowed—such as scheduled visitation hours, approved contact lists, monitored phone calls, and letter correspondence—while also imposing financial and logistical constraints on families (e.g., high costs for phone calls and difficulties arranging visits due to distance or security procedures) (American Bar Association, 2025). Phone calls, letters, and visits are typically controlled by correctional authorities, and limitations on approved contacts and schedules can effectively reduce the opportunity for meaningful communication with children These restricted systems not only limit quantitative contact but can also diminish the emotional quality of interactions**,** as phone calls may be short or monitored and letters subject to lengthy

delivery delays, undermining mothers' abilities to nurture emotional bonds and maintain caregiving roles from within prison (Navarro, 2025).

The impact of limited contact on parenting outcomes is evident in studies linking the frequency and quality of communication with maternal well-being and perceived parenting competence. More frequent contact—including regular phone calls and mail correspondence—can reduce parenting stress and support mothers' sense of connectedness and competence, even when physical visits are limited. When incarcerated mothers receive consistent contact, children exhibit fewer internalizing problems, such as anxiety and depression, and mothers report stronger feelings of attachment and parental efficacy. Importantly, the quality of contact—such as emotionally meaningful calls and letters that foster shared narratives and responsive dialogue—may be more impactful than sheer frequency alone, suggesting that qualitative dimensions of interaction (e.g., warmth, responsiveness, and emotional support) are crucial for sustaining mother–child relationships across incarceration (Ahlin, 2025).

Restricted communication systems in correctional facilities create significant barriers for incarcerated mothers, limiting both the frequency and quality of contact with their children. Policies that regulate visits, phone calls, and letters—often combined with high costs and logistical challenges—undermine mothers' ability to nurture emotional bonds and maintain caregiving roles. Consistent and emotionally meaningful contact, even if limited, supports maternal well-being, strengthens feelings of attachment, and enhances parenting competence, while also benefiting children's emotional adjustment. Ensuring both regular and quality interactions help sustain relationships and parental efficacy during incarceration.

Institutional Constraints Affecting Motherhood

Systematic barriers within the prison system, such as restrictive policies and inadequate support services, often impede incarcerated mothers from fulfilling their maternal responsibilities and accessing necessary resources. In addition, with increase in the number of female prisoners, it seems necessary to follow up the conditions of pregnant women in prison in order to identify their needs and provide healthcare and social services to improve their health accordingly. The needs of incarcerated pregnant women included healthcare, educational, supportive, counseling, and nutritional needs as well as those related to the substance abuse management. Identifying these needs can be useful in developing accurate and appropriate policies and programs to promote the health status of this vulnerable group (Alirezaei, 2022).

Women in prison are a vulnerable group, often with a history of abuse, out-of-home care, mental health problems and unemployment. Many are mothers when they become involved in the criminal justice system and their gender and parenting related needs are often not considered. Mothers have gender- and parenting-specific needs which should be considered in

planning for corrective services in Australia. Any service redesign must place the woman and her children at the center of the service (Breuer et al., 2021).

Systemic barriers in prisons, including restrictive policies and limited support services, make it difficult for incarcerated mothers—especially pregnant women—to meet their health, parenting, and emotional needs. Many female prisoners face histories of abuse, mental health challenges, and social disadvantage, and their gender- and parenting-specific needs are often overlooked. Coping strategies such as prayer, reflection, creative activities, social support from family and peers, and participation in livelihood or wellness programs help mothers manage stress, maintain emotional stability, and sustain connections with their children. These adaptive practices, along with resilience and commitment to maternal roles, allow mothers to navigate the pressures of incarceration and preserve their sense of identity. Programs that integrate healthcare, family engagement, skill-building, and spiritual support can strengthen maternal well-being and foster smoother reintegration into family and community life.

Coping Mechanism and Support System

Family is one of the closest people in helping individuals solve problems and serve as the foundation for developing coping strategies. Several factors influence coping strategies, including problem-solving skills and family support.

Moreover, female prisoners in penitentiary need motivation and support from family or closest people to avoid anxiety and emotional problems. Since they are apart from family support, to avoid anxiety and emotional problems, female prisoners can do positive coping strategies that can provide benefits to female prisoners how to relax, pray to get closer to each other's beliefs, support friends in prison, listen to music, joke, or try to think of good things, express feelings by

sharing with friends in prison, and help others. Coping is related to the form of effort made by individuals to protect against psychological pressures, due to social experiences. Hence, psychologically, good coping is able to provide strength effects (feelings about self-concept and life), emotional reactions, reduce levels of depression or anxiety, and balance between negative and positive feelings. Coping strategies used by prisoners will help them cope with the responsibility and pressure that comes with certain behaviors. The behavior that appears can be in the form of negative action responses, but can also be in the form of positive action responses through family support. Family support can come from parents, spouses or lovers, siblings, or even from loyal pets. With high family support, they have low-stress levels, are more successful at coping, and experience positive things in life more positively (Pamungkas et.al., 2023).

Coping activities through which the mental needs have been met were saturated crochet, manicures and pedicure, Zumba, reflection of prayer and participation in livelihood programs.

These activities provided a temporary distraction from their distress. There is currently in place various support programs, including religious and livelihood initiatives that are appreciated by families seeking inclusion; however, there remains a significant gap of intervention programs specifically targeting the enhancement of family relationships. It has been demonstrated in this and other studies the importance of such holistic support, not limited to mere rehabilitation but aiming at changes that regard quality of life and emotional aspects. Redemption and reconciliation from the perspective of incarcerated mothers, who desire to pick up what remains their lives and children revisit the dual issue area that attempts must address in order to establish a true continuum of service. Successful transitions into society are further facilitated by effective reintegration programs that include vocational training, family reunification services and community support (Salvador,2025).

Despite the numerous challenges faced by incarcerated mothers, their resilience, adaptability, and commitment to maintaining maternal bonds are visible. Their emotional, psychological, and spiritual strengths serve as vital coping mechanisms in navigating prison life. Ultimately, understanding these experiences can inform policies and programs that support their well-being and the well-being of their children (Karamarkovich, 2024).

Changes in Family Roles and Caregiving Arrangements

The incarceration of a mother often leads to significant family restructuring, with caregiving responsibilities redistributed to extended family members such as grandparents, relatives, or guardians. When mothers are imprisoned, children are frequently placed in the care of maternal grandparents or other kin, which fundamentally alters traditional family roles and caregiving dynamics (Sasaki et al., 2022). Grandparents, in particular, take on substantial caregiving duties, assuming not only the everyday supervision of children but also the emotional

labor associated with parental absence, often without adequate preparation or resources (Sneed, 2022). While kinship care can provide continuity and emotional stability, it also introduces new burdens for extended family members, including economic strain, role overload, and psychological stress associated with both caregiving and managing the repercussions of a relative's incarceration.

When a mother is incarcerated, family roles and caregiving responsibilities often shift to extended relatives, such as grandparents or other kin. These family members assume both daily supervision and the emotional labor of caring for children, frequently without adequate preparation or resources. While kinship care can provide stability and continuity for children, it can also create economic strain, role overload, and psychological stress for caregivers, reshaping traditional family dynamics and adding new challenges to households affected by incarceration.

Parent–Child Attachment and Emotional Bonding

Maternal incarceration disrupts attachment relationships between mothers and children, often leading to attachment insecurity and emotional distance that can persist into later development. Attachment Theory indicates that the separation caused by maternal imprisonment interferes with the child's ability to form and maintain secure emotional bonds, increasing the risk of insecure or disorganized attachment patterns, particularly when contact is infrequent or inconsistent document that many children of incarcerated parents exhibit behaviors reflective of insecure attachment syndromes, including ambivalent or avoidant responses toward caregivers and the absent parent, often rooted in repeated disruptions in caregiving continuity and emotional availability. Attachment security functions as a buffer against heightened stress responses in children experiencing parental separation, suggesting that children with stronger

attachments to stable caregivers show lower physiological stress markers compared to those with insecure attachments. The emotional distance and inconsistent caregiving associated with incarceration not only strain mother–child relationships but also have long-term relational effects, including difficulties in trust, emotional regulation, and social functioning, underscoring how attachment disruptions extend beyond the period of separation itself (Frion, 2022).

Maternal incarceration disrupts attachment between mothers and children, often creating emotional distance and insecurity that can persist into later development. Separation and inconsistent contact interfere with children's ability to form stable emotional bonds, leading to ambivalent, avoidant, or disorganized attachment patterns. Secure attachments with stable caregivers can buffer children from stress, while insecure attachments increase vulnerability to emotional and social difficulties. The strain on mother–child relationships extends beyond imprisonment, affecting trust, emotional regulation, and long-term relational functioning.

Stigma, Social Isolation, and Family Strain

Beyond caregiving and attachment disruptions, maternal incarceration is accompanied by intense stigma and social isolation that reverberates through the family system. Families of incarcerated mothers frequently confront social judgment and shame**,** often being labeled or treated negatively by community members, which fuels withdrawal and reduced social support (Cain, 2024). Extended family members who provide care for children may experience what sociological research terms "courtesy stigma," where they are stigmatized by association with the incarcerated parent, exacerbating emotional strain and marginalization (Gupta & Arditti, 2023). This societal stigma contributes to heightened isolation, as families may avoid disclosing the incarceration due to fear of discrimination, adversely affecting both the caregiver's and the child's social networks and emotional well-being (Cain, 2024).

1.3 Theoretical Framework

This study is grounded in Attachment Theory as proposed by John Bowlby (1969) and expanded by Mary Ainsworth (1978), which emphasizes the importance of a secure emotional bond between a mother and her child for healthy emotional and social development. According to the theory, disruption of this bond—particularly through prolonged and involuntary separation—can result in emotional insecurity, stress, and weakened relational ties for both mother and child.

In the context of incarceration, maternal imprisonment serves as a major disruptive condition that limits physical presence, emotional availability, and consistent caregiving. These limitations affect the mother's ability to perform essential maternal functions**,** such as nurturing, emotional support, guidance, and relationship maintenance. Institutional factors such as visitation policies, communication restrictions, and facility conditions further influence how attachment bonds are maintained or weakened during confinement.

Drawing from Attachment Theory, the study identifies key elements including maternal emotional experiences**,** psychological coping**,** communication with children**,** and family relationship dynamics as central constructs. These elements interact within the correctional environment, shaping how incarcerated mothers experience motherhood and family life while serving their sentence.

The framework assumes that disruptions in attachment caused by incarceration lead to changes in maternal identity, emotional well-being, and family dynamics. However, the presence of supportive institutional policies and consistent communication mechanisms may help mitigate these effects. By examining these elements, the study seeks to understand how imprisonment impacts maternal functions and family relationships, consistent with the study's title, *"The Lived*

Experiences of Incarcerated Mothers: Effect of Imprisonment Impact on Maternal Function and Family Dynamics."

1.4 Conceptual Framework

The study's conceptual framework is structured using the Input-Process-Output (IPO) model, a systematic approach for understanding how the research progresses from gathering essential information to generating meaningful insights about the lived experiences of incarcerated mothers.

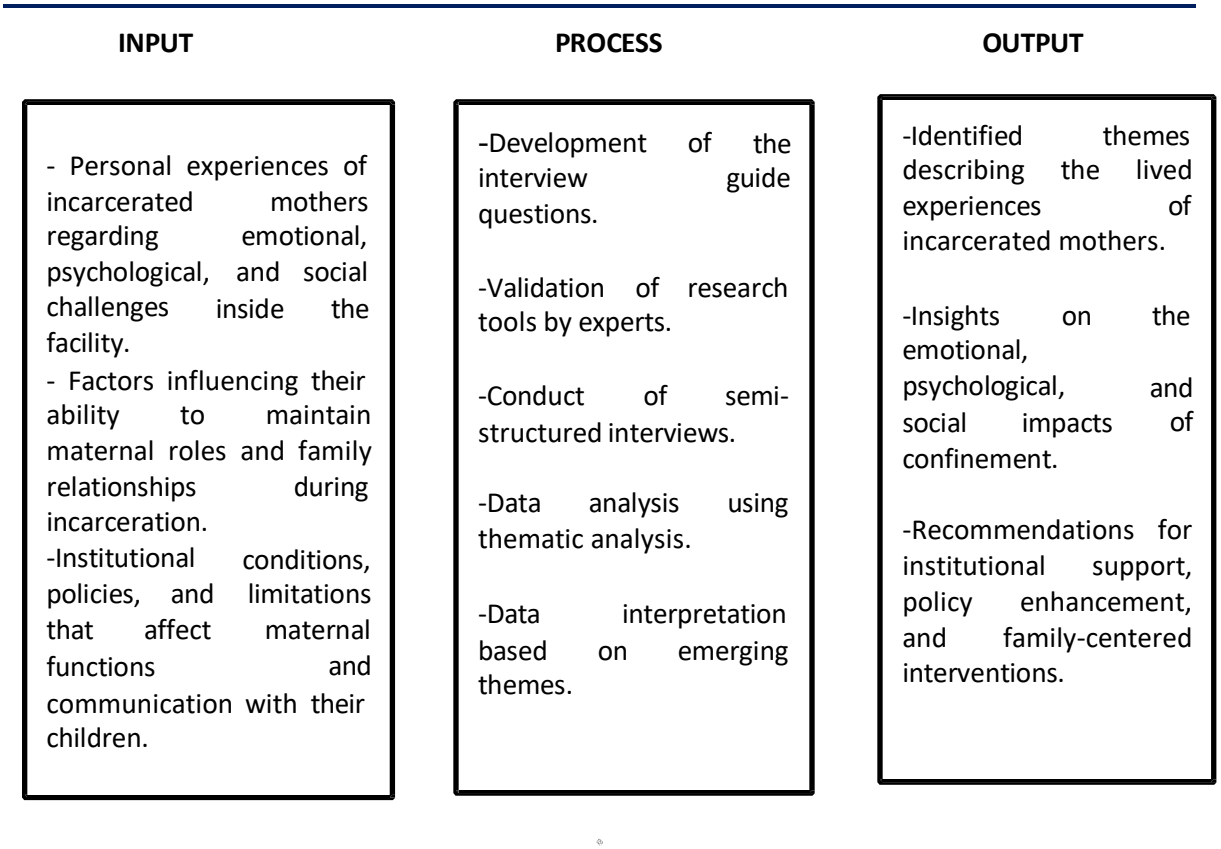


Figure 1. The Conceptual Framework of the Study

The study begins by examining the lived experiences of incarcerated mothers**,** focusing on the emotional, psychological, and social challenges they encounter within the correctional facility. It explores how confinement affects their ability to sustain maternal roles, maintain communication with their children, and cope with the realities of separation. These challenges include limited visitation opportunities, restricted communication channels, emotional distress, social stigma, and institutional restrictions that influence both maternal well-being and family relationships. Such conditions shape not only the mothers' emotional and psychological state but also their maternal identity, coping behaviors, sense of self-worth, and continued connection with their children and families. The input stage also highlights how institutional rules, facility

conditions, and policy limitations either support or constrain incarcerated mothers in fulfilling their maternal responsibilities while serving their sentence.

The methodology section outlines the systematic procedures undertaken to gather and analyze data for the study. Semi-structured interviews, guided by a validated interview questionnaire, are employed to elicit in-depth narratives from incarcerated mothers, allowing for rich, detailed, and contextually grounded accounts of their lived experiences. To ensure clarity, relevance, and sensitivity to the complexities of motherhood in confinement, the interview guide is subjected to expert validation before data collection. Following the interviews, the data are transcribed, coded, and analyzed using thematic analysis to identify recurring themes, emotional patterns, and relationships between the challenges faced and the coping strategies employed. The findings are then interpreted in relation to Attachment Theory, existing literature on incarcerated motherhood, relevant institutional policies, and the broader social context, enabling a comprehensive understanding of the phenomenon.

The framework's final stage focuses on generating meaningful insights and evidence-based recommendations to strengthen institutional support for incarcerated mothers. The outputs of the study include clearly identified themes that describe the emotional, psychological, and social impacts of imprisonment, as well as its effects on maternal roles and family dynamics. These findings inform practical recommendations such as improved visitation and communication policies, family-centered and attachment-focused programs, psychosocial support services tailored to the needs of incarcerated mothers, and institutional practices that uphold maternal rights and well-being. Ultimately, these proposed interventions aim to help incarcerated mothers maintain healthier familial connections, support emotional resilience, and contribute to more humane and responsive correctional environments.

1.5 Objectives of the Study

To explore and analyze the lived experiences of incarcerated mothers, with emphasis on the effects of imprisonment on their maternal functions and the dynamics within their families.

Specific Objectives

1. To explore the emotional, psychological, and spiritual experiences of incarcerated mothers as they navigate motherhood within confinement.
2. To determine how institutional policies and conditions affect the maternal functions of incarcerated mothers, including their capacity to nurture, communicate, and sustain relationships with their children.
3. To identify coping mechanisms and support systems that help incarcerated mothers and their families sustain emotional bonds and resilience during and after imprisonment.

1.6 Scope and Limitation

This study focuses on the lived experiences of incarcerated mothers confined at the Butuan City Jail in Libertad, Butuan City, Agusan del Norte. It examines how imprisonment affects maternal functions and family dynamics by exploring participants' emotional, psychological, and social experiences under confinement. The study includes incarcerated mothers who are both serving sentence and awaiting trial, recognizing that confinement, regardless of legal status, similarly restricts maternal roles, communication with children, and family relationships. Data are gathered through in-depth, semi-structured interviews with ten (10) purposively selected participants to obtain rich and meaningful insights.

The study is limited to a single city jail and a small number of participants, which may limit the generalizability of the findings to other correctional settings. As a qualitative phenomenological

study, it prioritizes depth over breadth and relies on self-reported experiences that may be influenced by emotional sensitivity, recall bias, or institutional constraints. Time limitations, security protocols, and jail regulations may also affect the extent of data collection. Despite these limitations, the study provides valuable contextual insights into the realities of incarcerated motherhood within the selected setting.

1.7 Definition of Terms

The following terms and statements were operationally and conceptually defined as follows:

Attachment. Refers to the emotional bond between a mother and her child that may be disrupted due to imprisonment.

Correctional Facility. Refers to the institution where incarcerated mothers serve their sentences under state supervision.

Family Dynamics. Refers to the interaction patterns and relationships among family members affected by a mother's imprisonment.

Family System. Refers to the interconnected structure of the family where the mother's incarceration impacts overall stability.

Imprisonment. Refers to the confinement of mothers in correctional facilities resulting in separation from their families.

Incarceration. Refers to the state of being confined in prison, limiting a mother's roles and responsibilities toward her children.

Maternal Function. Refers to the caregiving duties and responsibilities of a mother that may be hindered by incarceration.

Motherhood. Refers to the state of being a mother involving nurturing and caring for one's children despite confinement.

Mothering and Incarceration Conceptual Model. Refers to Kennedy's framework explaining how mothers maintain their identity within institutional constraints.

Parent-Child Relationship. Refers to the emotional and social bond between mothers and their children weakened by imprisonment.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter describes the methodology used in this study; it will explain the systematic approach taken to explore the lived experiences of incarcerated mothers. The purpose of the methodology chapter is to provide a clear and transparent account of how the research will be conducted, ensuring that the findings are credible, dependable, and trustworthy. In qualitative research, a well-defined methodology is essential because it shapes how data are collected, interpreted, and understood, directly influencing the depth and accuracy of insights.

In this research, utmost attention will be given to the research design, materials and methods, research environment, population and sample, data collection and analysis, and ethical considerations. Each part of the study will be carefully chosen and used to make the research strong and reliable. The research design will guide how the mothers' experiences are explored, and the sampling and data collection will help gather detailed and meaningful information. The analysis and ethical steps will support fairness, consistency, and respect for participants, making sure the findings will truly reflect the mothers' experiences and add useful knowledge about motherhood in prison.

2.1 Research Design

For this study, a phenomenological approach will be used to explore the lived experiences of incarcerated mothers. This qualitative methodology is well-suited for understanding the complex effects of imprisonment on maternal functions and family dynamics. By focusing on mothers' personal narratives, phenomenology allows researchers to uncover the depth of their emotions, challenges, coping mechanisms, and perspectives within the context of incarceration. Through face-to-face, in-depth interviews, this method will provide firsthand

insights into how incarcerated mothers navigate their maternal roles, sustain family connections, and experience the impact of imprisonment on family relationships (Creswell, 2013).

Phenomenology, as both a philosophy and research method, is based on the idea that reality is shaped by individual perception and that knowledge comes from careful reflection on experience (Hortillas & Gayoles, 2018). Guided by Husserlian descriptive phenomenology, the study will prioritize the participants' voices while applying epoché or bracketing, a process in which the researcher sets aside personal assumptions to focus solely on the mothers' perspectives (Englander, 2012). This ensures that interpretations remain grounded in the participants' accounts rather than influenced by preconceived notions.

Phenomenology is particularly appropriate for this research because it allows incarcerated mothers—an often-overlooked population—to share how they perceive and respond to the challenges of imprisonment. Their accounts will be analyzed thematically using Braun and Clarke's approach, which facilitates the identification of patterns and core themes across participants while preserving the richness of individual experiences. Instead of generalizing, this method highlights commonalities and differences in how mothers cope, maintain maternal identity, and manage family relationships, providing a nuanced understanding of motherhood under confinement (Lucerna & Gayoles, 2018).

In general, the phenomenological design offers a structured yet flexible framework to explore the realities of incarcerated mothers, capturing the depth of their experiences while ensuring methodological rigor, transparency, and respect for participants' voices.

2.3 Research Environment, Population and Sample

This study will be conducted at the Butuan City Jail, located in Libertad, Butuan City, Agusan del Norte. The facility serves as appropriate research setting as it houses both sentenced persons deprived of liberty (PDLs) and detainees awaiting trial**,** including incarcerated mothers who experience the challenges of sustaining their maternal roles and family relationships while under confinement. Regardless of legal status, confinement within the jail environment similarly imposes restrictions on physical presence, communication, and caregiving, making the site relevant for examining the lived experiences of incarcerated mothers.

Prior to data collection, clearance will be secured from the Bureau of Jail Management and Penology (BJMP) to ensure compliance with institutional protocols, ethical guidelines, and security requirements. The participants will consist of ten (10) incarcerated mothers, including both those serving sentence and those awaiting the resolution of their cases. Including both groups allows the study to capture a broader range of maternal experiences under confinement, while recognizing that the emotional, psychological, and social impacts of incarceration are present regardless of case status.

A purposive sampling technique will be employed, which is appropriate for phenomenological research as it enables the selection of participants who can provide rich, relevant, and meaningful insights into the phenomenon under investigation. The sample size is justified based on the principle of data saturation, ensuring sufficient depth and variation of lived experiences without unnecessary redundancy. The following criteria will guide participant selection:

(1) legal status as a female PDL with at least one child, whether residing inside or outside the

facility;

(2) a minimum of six (6) months of confinement, regardless of whether the participant is serving sentence or awaiting trial, to ensure adequate exposure to institutional routines and restrictions;

(3) demonstrated efforts to maintain maternal engagement, such as through letters, phone calls, or visitation when permitted; and

(4) voluntary willingness to participate and share personal experiences related to the emotional, psychological, and social challenges of incarceration.

This inclusive and clearly defined approach ensures that the data collected reflects authentic and diverse perspectives from mothers navigating motherhood under confinement, whether as sentenced inmates or detainees. It also acknowledges the vulnerability of the population and reinforces the study's commitment to ethical conduct, informed consent, and respect for participants' rights and dignity.

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

This qualitative study will use semi-structured interviews to explore the experiences of incarcerated mothers. Open-ended questions will allow participants to share their thoughts and feelings in their own words, describing the emotional, psychological, and social challenges of motherhood in confinement. All interviews will be audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim to ensure accurate representation.

The transcribed data will be organized and managed using ATLAS.ti, which will support systematic coding and retrieval. While the software aids organization, interpretation of the data will remain the responsibility of the researcher. Thematic analysis, following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-phase framework, will guide the process: familiarizing with the data, generating codes, identifying themes, reviewing and refining them, defining and naming them, and producing a narrative that captures the mothers' experiences.

To ensure trustworthiness, the study will apply strategies such as peer checking, adviser validation of codes and themes, and reflexivity to manage researcher bias. Credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability will be supported by careful documentation of analytic decisions, rich excerpts from participants, and bracketing of personal assumptions. This approach aims to provide an authentic and nuanced understanding of how incarceration shapes maternal identity, coping strategies, and family relationships.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

The conduct of this study will strictly adhere to established research ethical standards, ensuring the protection of the rights, dignity, and welfare of all participants and maintaining the study's trustworthiness.

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This study will uphold intellectual property rights by properly acknowledging all creative works, ideas, and research findings that inform its development. Authors, scholars, and institutions whose theories and materials are referenced will receive full credit, and APA style guidelines will be strictly followed to ensure accurate citation and academic integrity (Gupta, 2024).

All data generated from interviews will be treated as confidential and securely managed by the researcher. Licensed tools, such as ATLAS.ti, will be used to organize and analyze data, without reproducing any copyrighted software or instruments. Similarly, any literature or materials incorporated into the study will adhere to fair use principles, ensuring that no copyrighted content is reproduced without permission. By observing these ethical and legal standards, the study maintains credibility, transparency, and respect for both participants and the broader academic community.

B. Informed Consent

In qualitative research, informed consent is essential because it ensures that people participate freely after understanding the study's purpose, procedures, risks, and benefits. For this study involving incarcerated mothers, the consent process will be handled with extra care due to their vulnerability and the sensitive nature of the jail setting.

Before any interview begins, each participant will receive a written consent form that explains their rights, including the right to refuse or withdraw from the study at any time without punishment or adverse effects on their status in the facility (Burkhardt et al., 2023). For mothers with low literacy, the form will be read aloud slowly and clearly, and they will be given time to ask questions. This helps ensure that consent is truly informed and voluntary, as recommended by Mantica et al. (2024).

To prevent any form of coercion, no BJMP officer or staff member will be present during the consent discussion, and participation will never be linked to privileges, rewards, or disciplinary decisions. BJMP approval will also be secured before administering consent inside the facility to ensure compliance with institutional rules.

Participants will be reminded that they may withdraw from the study—or request that their interview data be removed—at any time before the final analysis. Confidentiality will be emphasized, and they will be assured that their responses will be used only for academic purposes and kept secure. This process ensures dignity, autonomy, and respect for all mothers who choose to take part in the study.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

To protect the privacy and safety of all participants, this study will strictly follow the Data Privacy Act of 2012 (RA 10173) and the policies of the Butuan City Jail. All personal and sensitive information shared by incarcerated mothers will be kept confidential and will be used only for academic purposes. Real names will not be recorded; instead, each participant will be assigned a pseudonym or code to ensure complete anonymity in transcripts, notes, and reports.

Only the researchers and the thesis adviser will have access to the digital and physical data. Digital files—including audio recordings and transcripts—will be stored in encrypted, password-protected folders. Printed materials such as field notes and consent forms will be kept in locked storage. The jail facility's additional restrictions on handling inmate information will also be followed, especially the rules against unauthorized copying or releasing of sensitive records.

All data will be kept for two (2) years after the study is completed, in line with institutional requirements. After this retention period, digital files will be permanently deleted from all

devices, and physical documents will be shredded to ensure that no information can be recovered. In the event of a data breach, the researcher will immediately report the incident to the research adviser, the institutional ethics committee, and relevant data protection authorities, as required under RA 10173. Steps will also be taken to secure affected files, strengthen safeguards, and prevent further risks.

By applying these precise and careful procedures, the study aims to protect participants' rights, maintain their dignity, and uphold the highest ethical and responsible research standards.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw

Participation in this study will be entirely voluntary. The mothers will be clearly told that saying "no" will not affect their jail status, privileges, or treatment. To avoid any pressure, BJMP personnel will not be involved in recruiting participants or in attending interviews. The researchers will personally explain the study neutrally and respectfully, ensuring that no inmate feels obligated to participate.

Before each interview, participants will be reminded that they may skip any question or stop the interview at any time. If they choose to withdraw after the interview, their audio recording and transcript will be deleted immediately, ensuring that none of their information remains in the study.

Since talking about personal experiences may cause emotional discomfort, interviews will be done in a private and safe space inside the facility. The researcher will use a calm and non-judgmental approach to help participants feel at ease. If a participant shows signs of distress, the interview will be paused, and she will be referred to the facility's social worker or counselor for support.

These safeguards will help protect the safety, dignity, and emotional well-being of the incarcerated mothers, ensuring that their participation is free from coercion and handled with care and respect.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

To minimize potential harm, this research will incorporate measures to identify and mitigate any physical, emotional, or psychological risks. Although the study will be designed to pose minimal risk, precautions will be taken to ensure that interview questions do not cause discomfort or distress among participating incarcerated mothers.

Following Woods et al. (2022), the study will anticipate possible emotional triggers and establish support mechanisms if participants experience unease. Participants will be assured of their right to skip questions or stop the interview at any time.

Risk management strategies will include debrief ing participants after each session and adopting a neutral, non-judgmental tone throughout discussions. By prioritizing participant well-being, the study will uphold ethical responsibilities and ensure that the pursuit of knowledge does not compromise respondents' dignity or emotional safety.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

Beneficence will guide this study by ensuring that the research creates meaningful benefits while keeping participants safe. Although the mothers will not receive direct rewards, their stories may help improve programs and services in the jail. The findings can guide BJMP, local government units, and partner organizations in developing better visitation policies, counseling services, and family-support programs for incarcerated mothers.

The study also aims to offer practical recommendations for policymakers, social workers, and NGOs working with vulnerable women and children. While the research cannot claim to solve all

issues—especially since qualitative studies gather insights from a small group—it can highlight real experiences that may inspire more humane and responsive institutional practices.

A summary of the results will be shared with the BJMP and other stakeholders, and participants may request a simplified copy if they wish. Through this approach, the study hopes to honor the voices of incarcerated mothers and contribute to gradual, meaningful change in their lives and in the correctional system.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

In research, justice requires that participants are treated equitably and selected fairly, free from bias or discrimination. This study will select incarcerated mothers based on their relevance to the research question, avoiding selection based on convenience or personal preference.

As O'Brien et al. (2022) articulate, justice in recruitment entails providing equal opportunities for involvement while safeguarding vulnerable populations from exploitation. All invited participants will receive equal access to information, consent forms, and interview procedures. The principle of justice further requires a fair distribution of benefits, ensuring they are not limited to select individuals or groups. Maintaining fairness throughout the research process will reinforce ethical accountability and strengthen the study's integrity.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

Data integrity and accuracy will represent the honest and meticulous gathering, analysis, and presentation of research results. All interview data will be transcribed verbatim and analyzed with objectivity to minimize distortion or bias.

Consistent with Mutai (2024), data integrity will be paramount in guaranteeing that interpretations accurately represent participants' experiences rather than the researcher's assumptions. To validate the findings and ensure consistency, the study will employ

triangulation and peer-review techniques. These strategies will strengthen credibility and support the production of trustworthy research outcomes.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

This study acknowledges the use of AI tools, including artificial intelligence-assisted writing and data organization platforms, to support the development of research materials, enhance clarity, and improve the overall quality of written outputs. These tools were used solely as aids and did not influence the integrity or objectivity of the research findings. There are no known conflicts of interest associated with this study. The researcher affirms that all findings will be reported truthfully and transparently, in accordance with strict academic and ethical standards. Furthermore, all copyrighted materials utilized throughout the study will be adequately cited and acknowledged in accordance with ethical research guidelines.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

No patented technologies will be used without proper clearance from the patent holders. Copyrighted materials, such as software and literature, will be utilized with appropriate permissions and citations. Adequate acknowledgement of sources will be observed to ensure transparency.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

Human participants will be thoroughly informed about the study's purpose, their roles, potential risks (such as emotional distress), and expected benefits. Informed consent will be obtained voluntarily, with assurances that participants can withdraw at any time without consequences. Strict confidentiality and anonymity protocols will be followed, and all data collected will be stored securely with restricted access to protect participant privacy.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Other Related Technologies

In this study, digital tools will be used only to support the research process, not to replace the researcher's judgment. NVivo, a qualitative data analysis software (not an AI tool), will be used to organize transcripts, manage codes, and maintain well-organized data. It will not generate interpretations or themes on its own.

ChatGPT will be used only for language-related support, such as improving grammar, refining sentences, and helping clarify the wording of the manuscript. It will not be used to identify themes, interpret participant experiences, or analyze qualitative data.

To maintain accuracy and ethical standards, all AI-assisted outputs will be carefully reviewed, verified, and edited by the researcher to ensure that meaning is not altered and no bias is introduced. Human judgment will guide all decisions related to coding, analysis, and interpretation.

All uses of NVivo and ChatGPT will be clearly and transparently reported in the methodology section to ensure academic integrity and accountability.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval

Since this is still a proposal, ethical approval has not yet been granted. After the successful proposal defense, the researcher will submit all required documents to the SMCC Institutional Research Ethics Committee for review and approval. Once ethics clearance is obtained, the researcher will also secure formal permission from the Bureau of Jail Management and Penology (BJMP) and the jail administrator of Butuan City Jail.

Data collection will begin only after both the ethics committee and the BJMP have granted full authorization. No interviews or any form of data gathering will take place without these approvals, ensuring that the study follows proper ethical and institutional procedures.

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